PART III · EXPRESSION · 5

Ornaments

Ornaments are decorations: a small sign that stands for a quick burst of notes around the main note. They borrow the notes **next door**, one letter name up or down: on D, the note above is E and the note below is C.

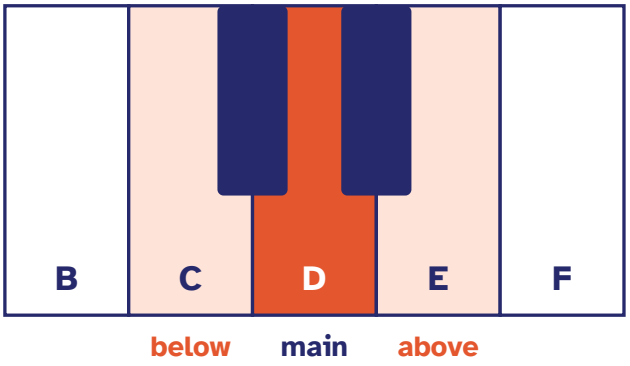
THE SECRET

An ornament is a necklace on the note: it borrows the next-door notes, and the main note still lands on time.
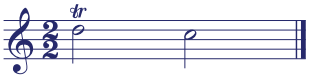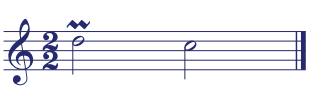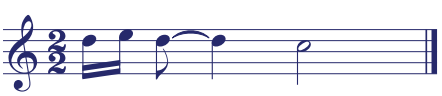


A small sign, a burst of notes

Next-door notes



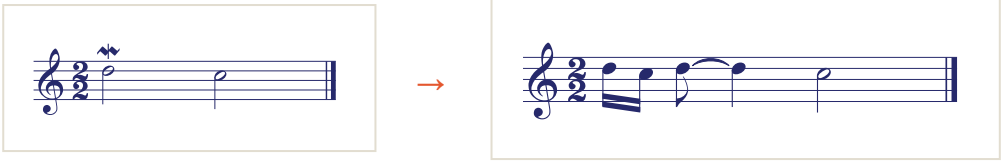
Plain letters on white keys: no sharps or flats unless the music adds one.

Written and played

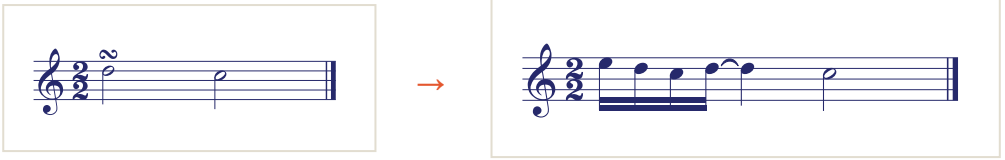
	WRITTEN		PLAYED
trill the note and the one above, back and forth		→	
upper mordent note, above, note: one flick		→	

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

lower mordent
note, below, note

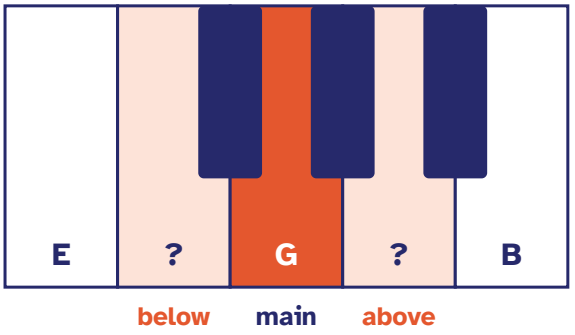


turn
above, note, below, note



EXAMPLE 1

A lower mordent on G

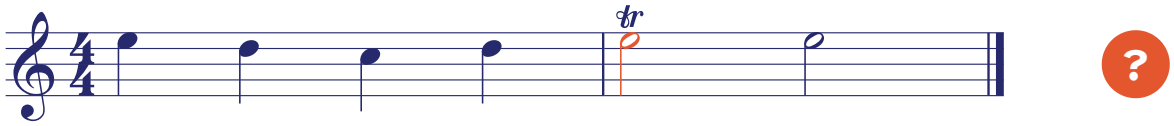


1. **The main note** is G.
2. **A lower mordent** borrows the note next door: above or below?
3. **Play it:** main, next door, main.

The note below G is **F**: **G F G**, one quick flick, then on. (A trill on G would use A, the note above.)

EXAMPLE 2

How do you play this trill?



1. **Which note** has the tr?
2. **Its next-door note above** is...?
3. **Go back and forth** for how long?

On the E: **E F E F...** quickly for its two beats, then the last E on time.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Where does a trill start?

In music from the 1700s (Bach, Handel), a trill usually starts on the note **above**: F E F E on an E. In later music it starts on the main note. Your teacher or the edition will tell you.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

Tiny notes before the main note

A tiny note just before the main note borrows a moment from it. **With a slash** it is an **acciaccatura**: crushed in, as fast as you can. **Without a slash** it is an **appoggiatura**: it leans, taking about half the main note's time.

EXAMPLE 3

Crushed, or leaning?



1. **Look for the slash** through the tiny note.
2. **With a slash:** how fast?
3. **Without:** how much time does it take?

Slash (acciaccatura): **crushed in**, almost at once. No slash (appoggiatura): **D for a crotchet**, then C.
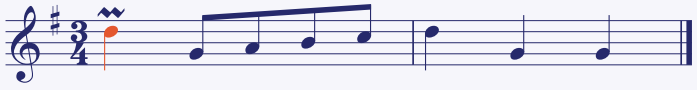
HOW TO

Practise an ornament

1. **Play the main notes** alone first, in time; then **add the ornament slowly**, as written-out notes.
2. **Speed it up** bit by bit, keeping the main note on the beat.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach)



Here the first D is decorated with a **mordent**: D, E, D, one quick flick, then the music walks on in time. The flick borrows from the D; the beat does not move.

Try it. Play the first bar with the mordent, then without it: hear the sparkle it adds.

THINK OF IT Ornaments are like accessories: a necklace or a hair clip makes you look lovely, but you get dressed first. Learn the plain notes in time, then add the ornament.

TRAP

× Starting a trill, mordent or turn before the beat: it begins on the beat. (Only the crushed acciaccatura slips in just before.)

SEE ALSO
The keyboard p. 22 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Library › Ornaments